compo.sh

A little order.
A lot of room.

USER GUIDE / VERSION 0.3.1 BETA

A native menu bar window manager for macOS 13 and later. Universal app for Apple Silicon and Intel.

Start here

1. Put compo.sh.app in Applications before granting permissions.
2. Open it manually. Choose Allow Accessibility Access and enable compo.sh in System Settings.
3. Close other window managers. Enable Automatic Tiling when ready.
4. Click the tiled menu bar icon whenever you want the controls.

This guide is bundled inside the app. Open Guide PDF works offline and opens your default PDF viewer.

Contents: setup and permissions (2), layouts and dragging (3), controls and rules (4), login and updates (5), troubleshooting and limits (6), workspaces and recovery (7).

01 / Permissions and first launch

Why Accessibility is needed

compo.sh reads window positions, moves and resizes windows, and focuses your chosen window through macOS Accessibility APIs. It does not record screen images. Visible-window metadata helps exclude windows on other Spaces.

Choose Allow Accessibility Access in the controls, then approve the app under System Settings > Privacy & Security > Accessibility. macOS owns approval; the app cannot grant access to itself. Return to compo.sh and enable Automatic Tiling.

Start paused

A fresh install starts paused. Granting Accessibility does not start tiling. Later launches remember your Automatic Tiling choice. Pausing leaves windows at their current positions and restores native tiling preferences saved by compo.sh.

Manual launch vs login launch

Opening the app yourself opens controls. Launch at Login starts silently in the menu bar, with no controls window or permission alert. If access is missing, open controls using the menu bar icon to see the permission explanation. Silent launch does not bypass permissions.

Only one manager

Quit AeroSpace, yabai, or other window managers while testing compo.sh. Multiple managers can repeatedly resize the same windows.

02 / Layouts, snapping and swaps

App-Aware Layout

Browsers receive more width than terminals when paired. Terminals and documents prefer tall columns. Two browser windows use wide rows. Safari plus Word uses tall side-by-side panes. App rules can override classification. If multiple companion columns would become too narrow, they stack into a balanced two-column grid. Ultrawide displays retain full-height companion columns.

Manual layouts

Turn off App-Aware Layout or click a layout button: Stack gives one main pane with companions; Columns gives equal tall panes; Rows gives equal wide panes. Window Gap changes spacing. Main Width applies to manual Stack.

Snap Edges

While Automatic Tiling and Snap Edges are on, drag a managed window to an edge or corner. A foreground outline previews the destination; release to snap. Left and right create halves; corners create quarters; the top edge fills the usable display. Bottom creates a bottom half. Edge Reach controls activation distance.

On macOS 15 and later, compo.sh temporarily disables native edge, top-edge, and Option-drag tiling preferences. Previous values return when Snap Edges is off, tiling is paused, or the app quits normally. These macOS preferences are undocumented and can change after OS updates.

Drag to Swap and animation

Drag a window into another managed window to preview a position swap. Release to swap. Disable All Animations is on by default. Turn it off for short swap transitions that respect Reduce Motion. Manual placements remain until window membership changes or you choose Retile Now. Apps may enforce minimum sizes.

03 / Keyboard controls and app rules

Keyboard controls

Ctrl + Opt + Cmd + Left / Right	Instant previous / next desktop
Control + Option + Z	Undo last arrangement
Control + Option + arrows	Focus in that direction
Control + Option + Shift + arrows	Swap in that direction
Control + Option + L	Cycle manual layouts
Control + Option + Space	Float or tile focused window
Control + Option + Return	Zoom focused window
Control + Option + P	Pause or resume
Control + Option + R	Clear placement and retile

Edit App Rules

Edit App Rules creates and opens a JSON file in your default editor. Use exact app bundle identifiers. Reload Rules applies edits; invalid JSON keeps the last working rules and shows an error. Maximum file size is 256 KB.

```
File: ~/Library/Application Support/compo/config.json
```

```
{"apps": {
  "com.apple.Safari": {"role": "browser"},
  "com.apple.Terminal": {"role": "terminal"},
  "com.apple.calculator": {"floating": true}
}}
```

Allowed roles: browser, terminal, document, other. Floating apps stay outside tiling. Manual floating and zoom last only for the current session. Edit Shortcuts opens shortcuts.json; Reload Shortcuts validates keys and modifiers. Duplicate chords or system conflicts keep previous working bindings. Keep all action entries; use enabled: false to disable one. Keys use physical US keyboard positions.

04 / Silent startup and safe updates

Launch at Login

Enable Launch at Login in controls to register with macOS. If approval is needed, use Approve in Login Items and finish in System Settings. The switch reflects the actual macOS registration state. Nothing enables it automatically on a fresh install.

On your next login the app starts silently in the menu bar. It uses your saved tiling and snapping choices. Click the menu bar icon to open controls. Opening the app manually still opens controls.

What survives updates

Automatic Tiling, App-Aware Layout, chosen layout, gap, main width, Snap Edges, Drag to Swap, animation, and Edge Reach persist in the app's preferences. App rules live separately in Application Support. Login registration is managed by macOS and remains attached to the stable app identity and location.

Update procedure

1. Quit compo.sh using its controls so native tiling preferences are restored.
2. Replace /Applications/compo.sh.app with the complete new app bundle.
3. Keep the same Applications location. Do not delete preferences or Application Support.
4. Open manually once to confirm the update, or let the next login start it silently.

The bundle identifier remains dev.compo.app even though the display name is compo.sh. That preserves existing preferences. Updates must retain this identity and Developer ID signing team. An update does not unregister the login item or reset preferences. Your explicit changes in macOS Login Items remain authoritative; compo.sh will not silently re-enable an item you disable there.

macOS can still require renewed approval after a signing change, relocation, or system policy change. No app can guarantee those approvals survive every OS update.

05 / Troubleshooting and boundaries

Windows refuse to fit

Some apps impose minimum sizes or reject Accessibility writes. Float those windows or reduce the number of tiles. Dialogs, non-resizable windows, hidden apps, minimized windows, native fullscreen windows, and compo.sh itself are excluded.

Native snap still appears

Confirm Automatic Tiling and Snap Edges are on. If preference writes fail, controls show a message; check Desktop & Dock tiling settings. Native integration uses undocumented preferences, not private WindowServer hooks. macOS changes may require a future app update.

After a crash

A crash can leave native tiling disabled. Reopen compo.sh, then pause tiling or turn off Snap Edges to restore the saved native settings. If you cannot reopen it, change native tiling manually in System Settings > Desktop & Dock.

Permissions or startup problems

Keep one copy in Applications. If macOS no longer recognizes Accessibility approval, remove the old entry and re-add the installed app. Check System Settings > General > Login Items for startup approval. Updating with the same bundle ID and signing team reduces approval churn.

Stop or remove

Pause with Control + Option + P, or quit from controls. Before removing the app, disable Launch at Login, then quit normally. Revoke Accessibility if desired. Quitting does not restore earlier window frames.

Scope

compo.sh arranges existing windows. It is not a replacement compositor. Instant desktop shortcuts use an undocumented Dock gesture protocol on macOS 26.6 and later. No SIP changes or system-wide Reduce Motion changes. Native shortcuts and trackpad swipes keep their existing animations. Future macOS updates may require compatibility fixes.

Apple reference: Login launch event.

06 / Workspaces, undo and recovery

Undo

Use Undo in controls or Control + Option + Z after a snap, swap, float, zoom, layout change, retile or workspace restore. One previous arrangement is kept in memory. Closed windows are excluded; changing desktops clears undo. App size limits still apply.

Saved Workspaces

Enter a name and choose Save. Select a workspace, then Restore. The app saves bundle identifiers, display identities, relative pane sizes and floating state. Missing apps launch without taking focus; restoration waits up to six seconds for windows. Open documents yourself first. Same-app windows match by visible order, not title. Missing displays fall back to an available display. Existing size constraints still apply, and extra visible windows remain managed.

Workspaces persist in ~/Library/Application Support/compo/workspaces.json. Limit: 32 workspaces, 128 panes each. Save and Delete write atomically. A failed load preserves the existing file; fix it before saving again.

Settled overlap recovery

After placement, compo.sh checks actual window geometry. Settled overlap gets one fitting recovery per arrangement. Persistent refusal stops placement retries and shows guidance. Impossible minimum sizes require floating or closing a window, or a larger display. Retile Now clears learned limits and tries again.

Diagnostics and desktop indicator

Export Diagnostics saves local JSON: app and OS versions, display/window geometry, bundle IDs, requested frames, size limits and up to 200 recent events with uptime. No titles, document paths, content or screenshots. Nothing uploads automatically. Review before sharing.

Show Desktop Indicator briefly shows the confirmed desktop number without taking focus or animating. Toggle it off in controls if preferred. Hold Control, Option and Command while tapping either arrow successively; held arrows act once per press and rapid taps queue in order.